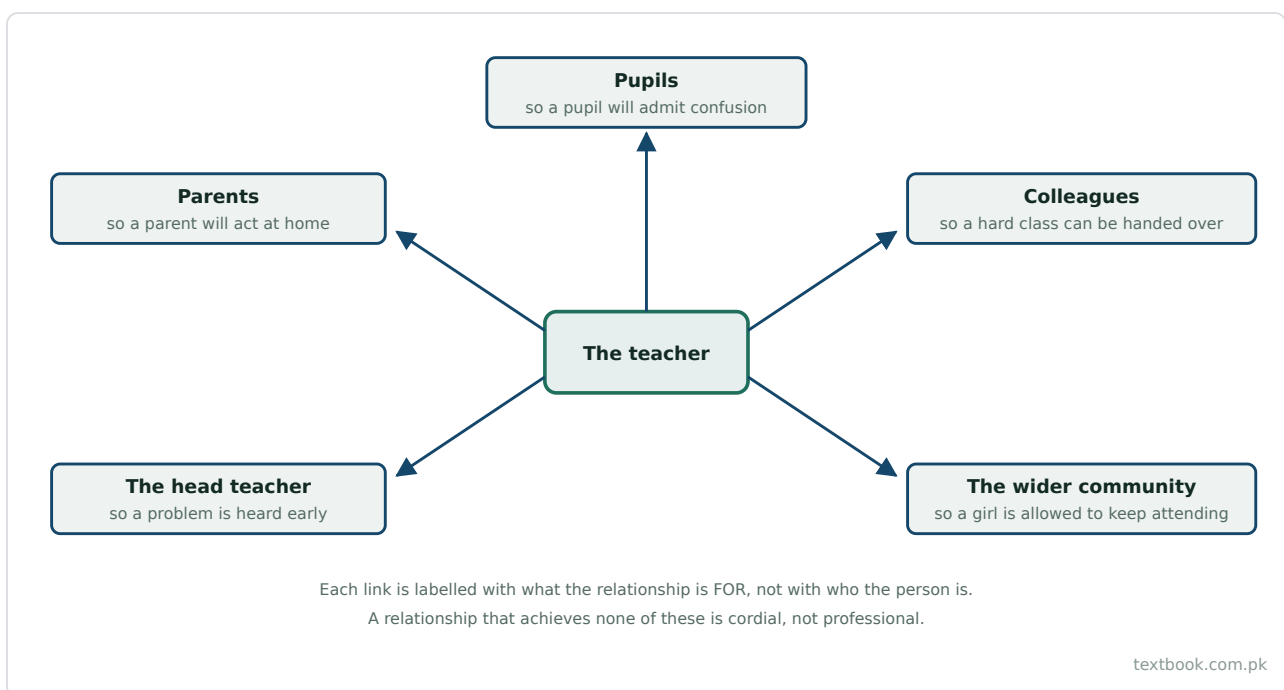


Topic 3.3 - Relationships, and what to do when they go wrong

A real classroom situation



A father arrives at the school gate at the end of the day. His daughter Hina has come home with a failing mark in the term test and the news that her teacher said she "does not try".

He is angry. He has been waiting since two o'clock. He begins in the corridor, in front of other parents and several pupils, and the first thing he says is that the school is punishing his daughter because the family cannot pay for tuition.

Miss Rehana has thirty seconds to decide what kind of conversation this is going to be. What she does in those thirty seconds will determine whether Hina gets

help this term.

Explanation

Building positive relationships with pupils, parents, colleagues and the community

The figure above deliberately labels each link with **what the relationship is for** rather than who is on the other end. Relationships in teaching are not decoration and they are not primarily about being liked. Each one exists because some part of the work is impossible without it.

Pupils. The relationship exists so that a pupil will admit confusion, attempt something they might fail at, and tell you when something is wrong. This is Unit 2's trust seen from the effectiveness side. It is built by reliability far more than by warmth: marking returned when promised, a rule applied the same way on a Thursday as on a Monday, a question taken seriously rather than deflected.

A misconception to clear early: *a good relationship with pupils means being liked*. Being liked is pleasant and it is not the goal, and pursuing it directly tends to produce a teacher who avoids the honest feedback a pupil needs. Pupils will forgive a teacher who is demanding. They do not forgive one who is unfair or unpredictable.

Parents. The relationship exists so that a parent will act at home, and so that you learn what you cannot see. A parent knows things about a child's week that no classroom observation will reveal. In a Pakistani context this relationship is often asymmetric in ways worth naming: a parent who did not complete school may find the building intimidating and a teacher's vocabulary excluding. The work of making the relationship usable falls on the teacher, because the teacher is the one with institutional power.

Colleagues. The relationship exists so that practice improves and so that a pupil is not handled inconsistently by six different teachers. It is also, as Unit 2 noted, where a profession's standing is held collectively.

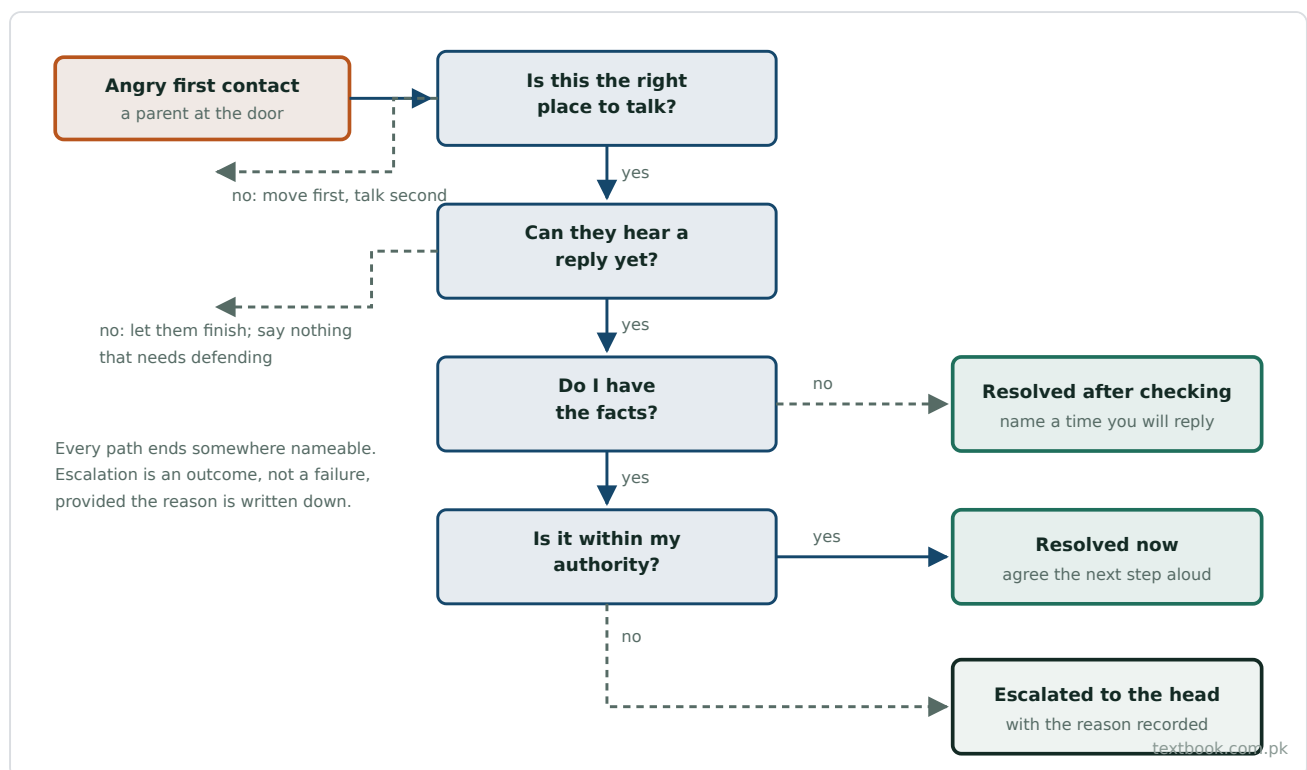
The head and the institution. The relationship exists so that you can get things done that require permission, and so that when you raise something

difficult it is heard rather than filed.

The wider community. The relationship exists because a school that the community trusts can ask things of it, and one it does not trust cannot. In rural Sindh this frequently determines whether girls stay in school past Class 5.

The common thread is that every one of these is a working relationship with a purpose. Judge them by whether they let the work happen, not by whether they are comfortable.

Managing conflict while maintaining professionalism



Conflict in a school is not a failure of relationships; it is a normal condition of a job where many people have a stake in the same child. What distinguishes a professional is the handling.

The sequence in the figure above is a workable default. Four decision points, in order.

Is this the right place? Almost never, if the answer involves a corridor and an audience. Moving the conversation is not evasion; it protects the other person's dignity as much as yours, and a parent who has lost face in front of neighbours cannot climb down. Miss Rehana's first move is to invite Hina's father to sit down somewhere else. Not to answer him yet.

Can this person hear a reply yet? An angry person is not processing argument. The move is to let them finish, and then to demonstrate you understood by summarising their concern back to them in their own terms before you say anything else. This is not a technique for managing people; it is genuinely finding out what the complaint is, and it is often not what the opening sentence claimed.

Do I have the facts? Frequently not. "I do not know, and I will find out and tell you by Thursday" is a stronger professional answer than a confident guess, and unlike a guess it can survive being checked. The obligation it creates is that you must then actually do it.

Is this within my authority? Some things are not yours to settle: a fee dispute, an allegation against a colleague, anything touching a pupil's safety. Escalating is not weakness. Escalating *without recording why* is, because it leaves the next person with no information.

Three things to hold throughout, which is where the professionalism in the heading lives:

- **Separate the person from the position.** Hina's father is not the problem; the belief that his daughter is being penalised for poverty is.
- **Do not defend a colleague reflexively, and do not sacrifice one either.** "I will find out what was said" is available and honest.
- **Never make a pupil the currency.** Whatever happens between adults, it cannot land on Hina.

Applied to the vignette: Miss Rehana moves the conversation, lets him finish, reflects back that he believes Hina is being treated differently because of what the family can afford, says that she does not know what was said and will find out, and tells him what she does know, which is the actual mark and what specifically Hina cannot yet do in the subject. That last part converts the

meeting from a grievance into something the father can act on, which is what Topic 2.2 meant about accurate information a parent can use.

Activity: The thirty seconds

Work in pairs, and take turns.

One person plays a stakeholder arriving in conflict; the other is the teacher. Run only the **first thirty seconds** and then stop. Scenarios: an angry parent in a corridor; a colleague who believes you undermined them in front of a class; a head teacher who has told you to change a mark; a community elder objecting to something you taught.

After each thirty seconds, the pair identifies which of the four decision points was actually in play and whether the teacher's opening move served it.

Swap roles and run a different scenario. Allow 25 minutes total. Resist the urge to play out the whole conversation: the opening is where most conflicts are decided and it is the part trainees have never practised.

Check your understanding

1. State what each of the five stakeholder relationships covered in this topic is for. (*Remember*)
2. Explain why reliability builds a stronger relationship with pupils than warmth does. (*Understand*)
3. Name the four decision points in the de-escalation sequence, in order, and say what each one protects. (*Remember*)
4. Apply the sequence to Hina's father and state Miss Rehana's first three moves. (*Apply*)
5. A teacher answers a parent's complaint immediately and confidently, and is later found to have been wrong about a fact. Analyse what that costs beyond the immediate error. (*Analyze*)

Summary

Every stakeholder relationship a teacher holds exists for a purpose that some part of the work depends on: pupils so that confusion is admitted, parents so that action happens at home and so that you learn what you cannot see, colleagues so that practice improves and handling is consistent, the institution so that things can be authorised, and the community so that a school can ask things of it. Judge relationships by whether they let the work happen, not by comfort or by being liked.

Conflict is normal in a job where many people have a stake in one child. The professional difference is in the handling: move the conversation somewhere dignified, let the person finish and show you understood, admit when you do not have the facts and commit to a time, and escalate what is not yours to settle while recording why. Throughout, separate the person from the position, decline to either defend or sacrifice a colleague reflexively, and never let the dispute land on the pupil.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can state what each stakeholder relationship is for rather than describing it as good or bad.
- ☐ I can explain why being liked is a poor goal and reliability a better one.
- ☐ I can work through the four de-escalation decision points in order.
- ☐ I can give an honest answer when I do not have the facts, in a form that creates a commitment.
- ☐ I can identify what is outside my authority and escalate it with the reason recorded.

Try this at your practicum school

Ask your mentor teacher to describe a conflict with a parent that ended well, and one that ended badly. Ask specifically what happened in the first few minutes of each.

Write half a page comparing the two openings against the four decision points. Most teachers cannot say why one went better, and the comparison usually reveals that the difference was location, audience, or whether the parent was allowed to finish.

Do not record identifying details.

Summative task

Write 400 to 450 words.

Miss Rehana has thirty seconds. Write what she should do, and defend it.

Set out her first three moves in order, justify each against a decision point, and then address the strongest objection: that moving the conversation and declining to answer immediately will read to an already-suspicious parent as the school closing ranks.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Use of the sequence (Apply)	Moves are in a defensible order and each is tied to a decision point
Realism	Accounts for the corridor, the audience and the waiting since two o'clock, not an idealised meeting
Answering the objection (Analyze)	Takes seriously that de-escalation can look like evasion to a suspicious parent, and shows what specifically prevents that reading
Protection of the pupil	Shows how Hina is kept out of the dispute and ends with something actionable for her

Further reading

- Hurst, B., & Reding, G. (2009). *Professionalism in teaching*. Pearson Education.
- Goe, L., Bell, C., & Little, O. (2008). *Approaches to evaluating teacher effectiveness: A research synthesis*. National Comprehensive Center for Teacher Quality. Cited here for relationships beyond the classroom as a component of effectiveness (sub-topic U3-07). It does not address conflict handling, which this topic's de-escalation sequence sets out as a reasoned default rather than a sourced finding.

<https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED521228.pdf>

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